PSYCHOLOGY

Chapter 3:

The Cognitive Approach

Welcome to AnithUncommon's **Sample Resources!**

We are assuming you are reading this as a student. So what will **YOU** expect from this sample?

In Psychology, The Cognitive Approach, 3.1-3.5…

This sample will be divided into **three** parts: Introduction to Samples (this part), Lesson Objectives (What is Expected From Students), and most crucially, Syllabus Contents.

Note that the 'Syllabus Content' does NOT stand as a complete syllabus itself; rather, it is a tight compilation of notes gathered by Sharia Shifa to create a comprehensive sample for students.

If you want a complete version of these notes and think that you need help in Psychology, join our nonprofit!

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This sample is made thanks to, Sharia Shifa

— Made by students, for students.

Lesson Objectives:

At the end of the lesson, students should be *able* to…

- **Understand** the "computer metaphor" of the mind (input, process, output).
- **State** the role of attention and concentration in memory performance.
- **Analyze** how false memories can be implanted and how they influence future behavior

Reflective Questions to Consider:

The cognitive approach is about how we think, pay attention, and remember information. It treats the mind like a system that processes input and produces output through mental operations.

So, think about these:

- Why do you think something as simple as “doodling” might help someone concentrate better?
- How do you think your brain decides what information is important enough to remember?
- Can two people see the same situation but remember it differently? Why?

Unit 3: The Cognitive Approach

Tip!
In the cognitive approach, don't try to memorize attention, memory, and perception as separate topics. Instead, always ask: "How does the mind process this information?" Think of the brain like a computer — it takes input, processes it, and produces output. So, doodling helps attention, false memories change stored information, and the Eyes Test shows how we interpret social signals.

Mnemonic (to remember the BIG idea):
"C-A-M = Computer, Attention, Memory"

Cognitive approach = mind works like a computer that processes attention and memory

Activities in Class:

- Lesson Breakdown
- Doodling Experiment Task: Try solving a simple task while doodling vs without doodling and compare focus levels (Andrade study link)
- Eyes Test Challenge: Guess emotions from images of eyes (Baron-Cohen study simulation)
- Memory Distortion Game: Recall a short story and compare how different people remember it differently (Laney study idea)

3.1 The Cognitive Approach

Information Processing Model

The cognitive approach explains behavior by treating the mind like an information-processing system, similar to a computer.

Mentor's Notes

The cognitive approach is all about understanding how the mind processes information like a system: input, storage, and output. Instead of

Information first enters the brain (**input**), is then processed through thinking, memory, and perception, and finally produces a response (**output behavior**).

Although mental processes like attention and memory cannot be seen directly, psychologists study them by observing behavior in controlled experiments.

This approach focuses on *how people think*, not just how they act.

3.2 Attention and Concentration (Andrade, 2009)

Doodling and Cognitive Load

Attention is the ability to focus on important information while ignoring distractions. However, the brain has a **limited capacity**, meaning it cannot focus on everything at once.

Andrade (2009) investigated whether simple activities like doodling could help improve concentration.

The study found that participants who doodled while listening to a boring task actually remembered more information than those who did not doodle.

This suggests that doodling prevents the mind from wandering, helping maintain focus instead of getting distracted.

It supports the idea that small tasks can keep the brain "active enough" to stay engaged.

3.3 Theory of Mind (Baron-Cohen et al., 2001)

focusing on the brain as a physical organ, this approach focuses on mental processes like attention, memory, and perception, which cannot be directly seen but can be studied through behavior and experiments.

When learning this chapter, always try to link each idea back to the "information processing model." For example, attention (like doodling in *Andrade*) helps control what information enters the system, memory distortion (like *Laney et al.*) shows that stored information can change over time, and theory of mind (*Baron-Cohen et al.*) shows how we

Reading the Mind in the Eyes

Theory of mind refers to the ability to understand what others are thinking or feeling, even without direct communication.

Baron-Cohen et al. (2001) tested this using the **"Eyes Test,"** where participants looked at images showing only the eye region of a face and had to identify the emotion being expressed.

The results showed that individuals with autism spectrum conditions often found this task more difficult compared to neurotypical individuals.

This suggests differences in how social and emotional information is processed.

It highlights how cognitive processes affect social interaction and empathy.

3.4 Memory Distortion (Laney et al., 2008)

False Memory Formation

Memory is not a perfect recording of events. Instead, it is **reconstructed**, meaning it can be influenced by new information, imagination, or suggestion.

Laney et al. (2008) showed that participants could develop **false positive memories**, such as believing they liked a food (e.g., asparagus) after being guided to imagine positive past experiences.

This shows that memory can be shaped or altered over time.

It also suggests that people may confidently remember things that never actually happened.

FUN FACT: A similar study was done by Elizabeth Loftus, where she implanted false/fabricated memory in the subjects' minds.

interpret and understand others' mental states. All three studies are basically showing different parts of the same system working together.

Tip!

Try to think of your brain like a "broken camera system." Sometimes it focuses (attention), sometimes it stores wrong pictures (false memory), and sometimes it misreads what people are feeling (theory of mind). If you remember this analogy, the whole chapter becomes easier to connect instead of memorizing separate studies.

3.5 Issues, Debates and Approaches

Nature vs Nurture

The cognitive approach mainly supports **nurture**, as it focuses on how experiences, learning, and interpretation shape behavior.

However, biological factors like brain structure and genetics can also influence cognitive abilities.

- This means behavior is influenced by both thinking processes and biological factors.

NOTE: You might confuse this with the 2nd chapter, *'The Biological Approach.'* Remember:

Biology – Nature (genes, hormones, etc)
Cognition- Nurture (environment, etc)

Reductionism

Reductionism refers to explaining complex human behavior by breaking it down into simpler processes.

The cognitive approach is sometimes reductionist because it compares the mind to a computer and simplifies thinking into steps like:
input → processing → output.

While this makes behavior easier to study scientifically, it may oversimplify real human experiences.

Evaluation Idea

The cognitive approach is strong because it studies mental processes in a scientific and structured way, often using experiments.

However, it may be limited because it does not always

consider emotions or biological influences. This means it explains *how we think*, but not always *everything that affects behavior*.	

Mentors’ Sources:

PSYCH book full.pdf

Andrade (2009) – Doodling and attention

Baron-Cohen et al. (2001) – “Reading the Mind in the Eyes” test

Laney et al. (2008) – False memory formation

Simon Baron-Cohen – Theory of mind and autism research

Elizabeth Loftus – Leading research on false memories

Alan Baddeley – Working memory mode